HongSeok Kim

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Citizenship: Republic of Korea (F1)

Education

Iowa State University — Ames, USA
Ph.D. in Economics — 2021 –
Advisor: Professor Juan Carlos Cordoba.

Hanyang University — Seoul, Republic of Korea
M.A. in Economics and Finance — 2021
B.A. in Economics and Finance — 2019

Research Interests

Macroeconomics, Public economics, Economics of Aging

Working Paper

[3] **Social Security and the Distribution of Effective Retirement Incentives**
HongSeok Kim

Abstract. This paper asks how much does Social Security transform a common payroll-tax reform into different effective labor wedges across older workers, and how much do those wedge differences change retirement behavior? Standard policy analysis often treats payroll-tax changes as uniform incentive shifts, but for seniors the relevant object is not the statutory tax rate itself. It is the effective wedge on work after the benefit formula, claiming rules, and the Retirement Earnings Test are taken into account. Exploiting the 2011–2012 U.S. payroll-tax holiday with monthly SIPP data on workers ages 62–70, we find that retirement responses vary systematically with baseline tax exposure, claiming status, and the strength of marginal benefit accrual. Already-claimed workers respond most, consistent with facing a near-pure tax. A dynamic retirement model calibrated to pre-reform moments shows that the Retirement Earnings Test is a major barrier to pre-FRA work, and that benefit linkage sustains late-career employment. The policy incidence of payroll-tax reform for seniors depends on workers' institutional position within Social Security, not just on the statutory rate.

Presentation: *WEAI Graduate Workshop*† *(2026), Macro Reading Group, Iowa State (2026)*

Work in Progress

[2] **Precautionary Retirement**
HongSeok Kim

Abstract. With Social Security's trust fund facing depletion, this paper studies how the system's regressive payroll tax shapes labor supply and retirement decision, motivated by an observation that high-income older males work more and longer. We develop a tractable labor supply model with heterogeneous work-costs, demonstrating that the elasticity of labor supply to financial incentives is inherently distributional. High-income workers, further from retirement cutoff, primarily adjust their hours (intensive margin), while those with higher work-costs adjust participation (extensive margin). Our central contribution is the measurement of these income group-specific elasticities, providing a framework to evaluate the distributional effects of policy reforms. We find seniors are 1.71 more elastic than the prime-age workers, implying that raising payroll tax rates may not resolve the solvency of Social Security.

[1] **Ambiguity Aversion and Fertility Decisions**
HongSeok Kim

Abstract. This paper investigates how ambiguity aversion affects fertility decisions, considering the uncertainty surrounding the benefits of parenthood. We extend the Becker and Barro (1988) fertility model by incorporating ambiguity aversion to capture parents' decision-making process accurately. We assume that individuals care about their own and children's well-being (dynastic altruism) and face ambiguity about their children's future abilities (ambiguity aversion). Using a multiple priors utility framework, we model parents' preferences as maximizing their minimum expected utility of descendants, focusing on the worst-case scenario for their child's ability. Our findings suggest that more ambiguity-averse parents tend to have fewer children, as they emphasize the lowest possible outcome. This insight helps explain declining fertility rates and rising childlessness in developed countries, as individuals prioritize predictable outcomes over uncertain returns of parenthood.

Presentation: *Southern Economic Association, Washington D.C (2024), 19th Economics Graduate Student Conference, Washington University in St. Louis (2024), Midwest Macro Meetings, Purdue (2024), Macro Reading Group, Iowa State (2024), Midwest Economic Association, Chicago (2023)*
†Scheduled.

Fellowships

Graduate Student Workshop Fellowship, Western Economic Association International	2026
Summer Teaching Assistantship, Iowa State University	2025
Most Engaging Presentation Award, EGSA, Iowa State University	2025
Best Discussant Award, EGSA, Iowa State University	2025
Research Travel Grant ($750) × 4, Iowa State University	2023–2025
Brain Korea 21 Plus Scholarship, Hanyang University	2020–2021
Academic Scholarship HY-IN Graduate School Scholarship, Hanyang University	2020
Academic Fellowship Korea Student Aid Foundation Fellowship	2019
Graduation Award, Hanyang University	2019

Seminar & Conference

North American Summer Meeting (NASM), Emory University†	2026
Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society, East & Southeast Asia (AMES), Vietnam†	2026
101th Western Economic Association International†	2026
Workshop on AI and Machine Learning for Economists, Iowa State University	2025
Southern Economic Association, Washington D.C	2025
19th Economics Graduate Student Conference, Washington University in St. Louis	2024
Midwest Macro Meetings, Purdue University	2024
Macro Reading Group, Iowa State University	2024
Midwest Economic Association, Chicago	2023

†Scheduled.

Academic Experience

Sole Instructor — Iowa State University

ECON 1020: Principles of Macroeconomics (*Eval: 4.36/5.0*) — Summer, 2025

Recitation Instructor – Graduate — Iowa State University

ECON 6020: Macroeconomic Analysis (Ph.D. Core, *Eval: 5.0/5.0*) — 2025F

ECON 6030: Advanced Microeconomics - Game Theory (Ph.D. Core, *Eval: 4.67/5.0*) — 2023S

ECON 6040: Advanced Macroeconomics Analysis (Ph.D. Core, *Eval: 5.0/5.0*) — 2024S, 2025S, 2026S

ECON 5710: Intermediate Econometrics (Masters) — 2026S

Teaching Assistant/Lab Instructor – Undergraduate — Iowa State University

ECON 1010: Principles of Microeconomics — 2021, 2023, 2024

ECON 1020: Principles of Macroeconomics — 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025

ECON 3020: Intermediate Macroeconomics (*Eval: 5.0/5.0*) — 2025

ECON 3710: Introduction to Econometrics (*Eval: 4.29/5.0*) — 2021

Academic Service

Discussions

"Urbanicity and Fertility: Evidence from Refugees to Canada",
– Midwest Economics Association Meetings, Chicago — 2024

Guest Lecture

ECON3270 (Economics of Discrimination)
– Quantity-Quality Trade-off of Gary Becker's Model — 2025

Other Service

Economic Help Room Services for the Undergraduates — 2021, 2023